“I have a gut feeling we should do this,” I wrote in my diary after I received another letter from Chernenko in June that repeated many of his earlier points. “His reply to my letter is in hand and it lends support to my idea that while we go on believing, and with some good reason, that the Soviets are plotting against us and mean us harm, maybe they are scared of us and think we are a threat.”

The 1984 election was coming up. Several of our Soviet experts told me not to expect any movement from the Russians until after it was over. Our intelligence analysts believed Chernenko and other Soviet leaders had decided not to respond positively to suggestions for a summit because they felt that if they did they would help me get reelected. I have no way of knowing whether that was true, but I wouldn’t be surprised if it was.

Over the next few months, we were to learn that to a large extent Chernenko was not as much in control of the Communist Party or the Politburo as Brezhnev or even Andropov, but shared it as spokesman for a kind of consensus leadership at the top of the hierarchy.

Like Andropov, we were told, Chernenko was ill and might not live long. When he appeared in public, he seldom said anything without a script. Another old hard-liner from the Stalin era, Andrei Gromyko, was calling the shots on Soviet foreign relations, and it was at his recommendation that the Soviets boycotted the Olympics.

In the middle of the summer, the Russians told George Shultz that they would be willing to return to the arms control table, but to discuss one item only, what they called the “militarization of space,” a reference to our research on the Strategic Defense Initiative.

The Soviets were demanding that we halt work on the SDI just as we were beginning to get indications from our scientists that it might work—and at a time when the